

SOP Documentation Workflow

Mary Langley | Combined workflow | Preparation and SME discovery

Your questionnaire-led process, combined with the additional validation, approval, and document-control steps discussed. Adapt reviewer roles and controls to the bank's established requirements. SME = subject matter expert; SOP = standard operating procedure; LLM = large language model.

1. Define the scope

Confirm the SOP purpose, intended audience, process owner, systems, triggering event, start and end points, and whether this is a new procedure or a revision.

2. Identify reviewers and approvers

Confirm the SME, process owner, designated approver, and any required Compliance, Risk, Legal, Information Security, Quality, or other reviewers under the bank's process.

3. Review existing documentation

Read the previous SOP and related policies, forms, job aids, system documentation, change requests, and available audit findings before preparing interview questions.

4. Create the fact-finding questionnaire

Ask about steps, inputs, outputs, responsibilities, decision points, exceptions, escalations, approvals, controls, timing requirements, regulatory requirements, and known pain points.

5. Send the questionnaire to the SME

Allow a couple of days before the interview so the SME can prepare answers, take notes, and gather supporting information.

6. Interview the SME using the questionnaire

Use the questions as a framework, clarify answers, and ask follow-up questions about missing details and what-if scenarios. Record the interview only when company policy permits it and the required consent is obtained; otherwise take detailed notes.

7. Validate the actual process

Where possible, use a walkthrough, screen-share, observation, or system demonstration to compare the described process with how the work is performed. Resolve differences before drafting.

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8. Research and reconcile supporting requirements

Research authoritative sources and compare the former SOP with the SME's answers. Check related policies, regulatory guidance, system references, and other approved resources; flag conflicts for the responsible owner.

9. Prepare materials for the approved LLM

If bank policy permits, provide your original questionnaire, the SME's completed questionnaire, interview notes or transcript, video if supported and authorized, previous SOP version, and relevant research materials to the approved enterprise LLM. Follow the bank's data-handling rules.

10. Create the rough draft

Use the gathered materials to draft the procedure in logical sequence. Include prerequisites, roles, steps, controls, decision points, exceptions, escalation paths, and references. Mark unresolved questions for review.

11. Review the draft for inaccuracies and gaps

Check the draft against the source materials. Correct missing steps, contradictions, unclear wording, undefined acronyms, sequencing errors, terminology, screenshots, and broken references. Verify AI-generated content rather than assuming it is accurate.

12. Obtain the required compliance and control review

Have the designated reviewers confirm applicable policy requirements, required approvals, segregation of duties, regulatory timeframes, and evidence-retention requirements. Track questions that still need resolution.

13. Send the draft and a targeted review questionnaire

Ask the SME specific questions about accuracy, missing steps, exceptions, and regulatory or policy issues. For example: Is this step before or after approval? What happens if validation fails? Is this required by policy or current practice?

14. Revise and repeat SME review

Take the questionnaire answers and reviewer comments into account, edit as needed, and return the draft to the SME until substantive issues are corrected. Track comments, decisions, and how each issue was resolved.

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15. Finalize formatting and document controls

Apply the bank's template and style standards. Include the document owner, version number, effective date, revision history, approval information, next review date, classification, related policies, and superseded version as required.

16. Obtain formal approval and sign-off

Route the final publication version to the designated process owner or approver. SME review alone may not constitute authorization to publish. Re-route substantive changes for approval when required.

17. Publish to the bank's chosen repository

Save the approved SOP to the authorized document-management system, knowledge base, or repository. Update version control, access permissions, and links so users can find the current approved procedure.

18. Archive or supersede the prior version

Preserve the previous version and approval history according to the bank's retention rules. Clearly mark superseded documents and prevent outdated instructions from being used as the current procedure.

19. Communicate the change

Notify affected employees, managers, trainers, and downstream teams as appropriate. Explain the effective date and significant changes; coordinate training or acknowledgement when required.

20. Schedule maintenance and periodic review

Set the next review date and accountable owner. Revisit the SOP when systems, regulations, policies, or processes change, and use feedback to identify needed revisions.

Interview summary: Research, SME preparation, discovery, validation, drafting, technical and compliance review, SME revision, approval, controlled publication, and maintenance.